Fail-Safe In-Orbit Reprogramming of a Spacecraft Controller

Hardware Trade Study

Reference	TBD [**TBD-1**]
Issue / revision	Issue 1, Revision 0 — DRAFT
Date	12 October 2026
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Open items	7 TBD, 1 TBR (App. B)

Document change record

Issue	Rev.	Date	Change
1	0	2026-10-12	First draft

1.0 Purpose and Scope

This study chooses the hardware of the bench on which the System is built and verified. It measures each candidate against the hardware needs of the architecture [2, Sec. 8.0] and the bench needs of the verification plan [3, Sec. 5.0], and prefers hardware the author already owns. It chooses in two steps: a first bench of owned boards only, and the parts the full bench adds.

2.0 Documents

[1] NASA, *NASA Systems Engineering Handbook*, NASA/SP-2016-6105 Rev 2, 2016.
[2] *Fail-Safe In-Orbit Reprogramming of a Spacecraft Controller — Software Architecture*, Issue 1, Revision 0, Draft.
[3] *Fail-Safe In-Orbit Reprogramming of a Spacecraft Controller — Verification Plan*, Issue 1, Revision 0, Draft.
[4] STMicroelectronics, *STM32G431xB Datasheet*, DS12589 Rev 6.
[5] STMicroelectronics, *STM32G4 Series Reference Manual*, RM0440 Rev 9.
[6] STMicroelectronics, *STM32G4 Nucleo-32 Board (MB1430)*, UM2397 Rev 2.
[7] STMicroelectronics, *Introduction to System Memory Boot Mode on STM32 MCUs*, AN2606 Rev 70.
[8] STMicroelectronics, *Discovery Kit with STM32MP257F MPU*, UM3385 Rev 2.
[9] Texas Instruments, *THVD14xx 3.3-V to 5-V RS-485 Transceivers*, SLLSEY3E, 2019.
[10] Texas Instruments, *TCAN33x 3.3V CAN Transceivers with CAN FD*, SLLSEQ7F, 2025.
[11] Texas Instruments, *TMUX1574 2:1 (SPDT) 4-Channel Switch*, SCDS391C, 2019.
[12] Linux kernel, `drivers/net/can/usb/gs_usb.c`, mainline, read 12 October 2026.
[13] `uhubctl` project, *README*, read 12 October 2026.
[14] STMicroelectronics, *STM32G474xB/xC/xE Datasheet*, DS12288 Rev 3 (distributor copy; later revisions not obtained).
[15] STMicroelectronics, *STM32G491xC/xE Datasheet*, DS13122 Rev 4 (distributor copy).
[16] STMicroelectronics, *STM32G4 Nucleo-64 Boards (MB1367)*, UM2505 Rev 4 (distributor copy; Rev 7 not obtained).
[17] D. Owens et al., "Efficient and Side-Channel Resistant Ed25519 on ARM Cortex-M4", *IEEE Trans. Circuits and Systems I*, vol. 71, no. 6, June 2024.
[18] Linux kernel, `Documentation/networking/can.rst`, mainline, read 12 October 2026.

3.0 Criteria

Each need of the architecture and of the verification plan is a criterion. Each candidate gets one of four answers for each criterion. Among candidates that meet the needs, owned hardware comes first, then the lowest cost.

Legend. MET: met as the board is. PARTLY: met only with a board change, or with a limit stated beside it. NOT MET: not met. TO MEASURE: settled only by a measurement on the bench [3, Sec. 7.6].

4.0 Controller

Three boards are assessed: the NUCLEO-G431KB, which the author owns, and two Nucleo-64 boards built on the same board design, the NUCLEO-G474RE and the NUCLEO-G491RE [16, p. 1]. A published Ed25519 verification on a Cortex-M4 takes 720 000 cycles [17, p. 2674]; two take about 8.5 ms at 170 MHz, a figure measured on the bench for each board [3, Sec. 7.6].

Need [2, Sec. 8.0]	NUCLEO-G431KB	NUCLEO-G474RE	NUCLEO-G491RE
Clock and RAM for two signature checks	TO MEASURE: 170 MHz, 32 KB SRAM [4, pp. 1, 14]	TO MEASURE: 170 MHz, 128 KB SRAM [14, Sec. 3.5, p. 20]	TO MEASURE: 170 MHz, 112 KB SRAM [15, Sec. 3.5, pp. 18–19]
Flash; writing while running	PARTLY: 128 KB, one bank; a page erase stalls code for up to 24.47 ms [5, p. 195; 4, p. 107]	MET: 512 KB in two banks, read-while-write with the DBANK option bit set [14, Sec. 3.4, p. 19; 5, Sec. 3.3.8, p. 108]	PARTLY: 512 KB, one bank; erase stalls code [5, p. 156]
UART for data link A	PARTLY: USART2 wired to the ST-LINK by default [6, p. 16]	MET: UART5, apart from the factory loader's UARTs [14, p. 75]	MET: UART5 [15, Table 13, p. 65]
CAN FD controller	MET: one [4, Table 13, p. 61]	MET: three [14, Table 2, p. 15]	MET: two [15, p. 14]
SWD with full memory access	PARTLY: reaches only the on-board ST-LINK [6, pp. 22–23]	MET: PA13/PA14 on header CN7 pins 13 and 15 [16, Table 16, p. 31]	MET: same board as the G474RE [16, Table 16, p. 31]
Factory loader on its own UART	MET: USART1 [7, Table 115, p. 274]	MET: USART1 to 3 [7, Table 117, p. 279]	MET: USART1 to 3 [7, Table 119, p. 285]
NRST and BOOT pins accessible	PARTLY: BOOT0 not on a header [6, p. 16]	PARTLY: NRST on CN7 pin 14; BOOT0 on CN7 pin 7 but not connected by default [16, Table 16, pp. 31–32] **[TBD-2]**	PARTLY: same board as the G474RE
Independent watchdog	MET [5, p. 1557]	MET [5, p. 1557]	MET [5, p. 1557]
RTC with an independent clock source	PARTLY: internal oscillator only, 29.5 to 34 kHz [4, pp. 51, 105]	MET: 32.768 kHz crystal fitted [16, Sec. 6.5.2, p. 22]	MET: same board as the G474RE
Owned	YES	NO	NO

5.0 Onboard Computer

The only candidate is the STM32MP257F-DK, which the author owns. Its 40-pin header carries one UART, USART6, on pins 8 and 10 [8, Table 24, p. 35]. It has two USB Type-A host ports [8, p. 2].

Need [2, Sec. 8.0]	Answer	STM32MP257F-DK
UART for data link A	MET	USART6 on the header [8, Table 24, p. 35]
UART to the factory loader	PARTLY	No second UART documented on the header; a USB-to-RS-422 adapter on a host port meets it **[TBD-3]**
CAN FD controller with transceiver	PARTLY	No CAN signal on the header and no transceiver on the board [8, Table 24, p. 35]; a USB CAN FD adapter meets it, with CAN FD support in the mainline Linux driver [12, ll. 181, 969]
Four GPIOs: SWDIO, SWCLK, NRST, BOOT	MET	Free header pins, for example PZ0, PZ1 and PZ9 on pins 15, 16 and 13 [8, Table 24, p. 35]
Storage for two firmware stores	MET	8 GB eMMC and a microSD slot [8, pp. 2, 18]

6.0 Interface Parts and Bench Tools

No ready-made modules were found for the transceivers below; they are mounted on small adapter boards.

Need	Candidate	Count	Facts
RS-422 line drivers, data link A and factory loader	TI THVD1451	4	3 to 5.5 V supply; full duplex; up to 50 Mbps [9, p. 1; Table 5, p. 4]
CAN FD transceiver	TI TCAN332G	2	Single 3.3 V supply; CAN FD up to 5 Mbps [10, p. 1]
Debug port shared by the probe and the onboard computer [3, Sec. 5.0]	TI TMUX1574	1	Four 2:1 switches, so SWDIO, SWCLK, NRST and BOOT change over together; 1.5 to 5.5 V supply [11, p. 1]
Controller power cut at a chosen moment [3, Sec. 5.0]	USB hub with per-port power switching	1	Switched from a script by `uhubctl` [13, Sec. What is USB per-port power switching?]; the hub model **[TBD-4]**
Events time-stamped from one clock [3, Sec. 5.0]	Logic analyzer	1	Model **[TBD-5]**
Data link cut and bytes changed on command [3, Sec. 5.0]	Board in the middle of the link	1	Board **[TBD-7]**

7.0 Selection

7.1 First Bench

The first bench uses only the two owned boards (Figure 1). The NUCLEO-G431KB's USB plugs into a host port of the STM32MP257F-DK. Through the on-board ST-LINK, one cable gives the onboard computer the controller's USART2 as data link A [6, p. 16] and the controller's SWD port for the restore. Power is cut by hand, and events are time-stamped by the onboard computer's clock. It costs nothing.



Figure 1: The first bench: owned hardware only.

It shows the update, the trial, the return to the previous copy, the refusal of damaged and forged images, and the restore of an erased controller. It does not show data link B, the RS-422 and CAN electrical links, the restore through the factory loader, SWD driven from the onboard computer's own pins, or power cuts made by a script.

7.2 Owned-Hardware Bench

The bench then grows with jumper wires and one soldered wire, buying nothing (Table 1). The onboard computer's second UART stands in for data link B and also reaches the factory loader. Its NRST line resets the controller at a chosen moment, in place of a power cut. A bench-only program on the onboard computer drops, cuts or changes bytes on a link, in place of a link tool. The CAN FD software is tested on each end alone: the controller's with its CAN controller in loop-back test mode [5, Sec. 44.2, p. 1953], the onboard computer's on a virtual CAN interface, which sends and receives CAN frames "without real CAN controller hardware" [18, Sec. The Virtual CAN Driver (vcan)]. Before wiring, the high level of a header pin of the onboard computer is measured **[TBD-6]**.

STM32MP257F-DK	NUCLEO-G431KB	Use
USB Type-A port	USB port	Data link A (ST-LINK serial port); SWD for the restore and the debug probe
USART6 TX, CN5 pin 8	PA10, CN4 pin 2	Data link B and the factory loader's UART
USART6 RX, CN5 pin 10	PA9, CN4 pin 1	Data link B and the factory loader's UART
GND, CN5 pin 6	GND, CN3 pin 2	Common ground
PZ0, CN5 pin 15	NRST, CN3 pin 3	Reset, pulled low only
PZ1, CN5 pin 16	PB8 (BOOT0), soldered wire	Boot pin for the factory loader
PZ9, CN5 pin 13	PB0, CN4 pin 6	Event line, time-stamped by the onboard computer

Table 1: Wiring of the owned-hardware bench [8, Table 24, p. 35; 6, Table 11, p. 22; 6, p. 16] **[TBR-1]**.

It runs every verification activity except those on the RS-422 and CAN electrical links, on a true power cut, and on SWD driven from the onboard computer's own pins. The parts of Section 6.0 add those later.

A Acronyms

CAN FD Controller Area Network with Flexible Data rate
GPIO General-purpose input/output
NRST Reset pin
RTC Real-time clock
SWD Serial Wire Debug
TBD To Be Determined
TBR To Be Resolved
UART Universal asynchronous receiver-transmitter
USB Universal Serial Bus

B Open Items

The values below are not yet known.

TBD-1 Project name and document reference.
TBD-2 The board change that connects BOOT0 to header CN7 on the Nucleo-64 boards; settled by the board schematic.
TBD-3 Whether the STM32MP257's pins can put a second UART and CAN FD on the header; settled by its datasheet.
TBD-4 The USB hub model.
TBD-5 The logic analyzer model.
TBD-6 The logic level of the onboard computer's header pins; 3.3 V expected, measured before wiring.
TBD-7 The board placed in the middle of a data link.

Accepted by the author on 12 October 2026: the first bench (Section 7.1); the NUCLEO-G431KB as the controller; the owned-hardware bench (Section 7.2). The proposal below awaits the author's acceptance.

TBR-1 The pin choices of Table 1.